

Google's India ambition for Pixel

Google India's Mitul Shah on making Pixel a mass-market brand in India

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With the launch of the Pixel 11 series, it is pretty evident that Google is laser-focused on cracking the code for the Indian smartphone market. Beyond customizing AI solutions for India, Google has also expanded Pixel's retail and after-sales presence, introducing initiatives such as the Pixel Upgrade Programme making it easier to move to a new Pixel.

To address all things Pixel, I spoke to Mitul Shah, Managing Director of Devices and Services at Google India, about the company's smartphone strategy, the role of AI, India-specific Gemini experiences, pricing, retail expansion, and what Google needs to do to challenge Apple and Samsung in the premium smartphone market.

Q What do you believe is the single biggest reason an Indian consumer should choose a Pixel?

A Mitul Shah: I wake up every morning with two clear missions on my mind. We want to put AI-powered devices in the hands of Indians, and we want to solve the hardest problem

in this market, in this industry, which others have not attempted. One of the hardest problems is: can we put more cutting-edge technology to as many Indian consumers as possible?

So, it's not about competition; to be very honest, it's about giving choice to our customers.



Mitul Shah
Managing Director of
Devices and Services at
Google India

Q What has changed in the way Indian consumers buy and experience Pixel, and where do you still see the biggest gaps?

A Mitul Shah:

We're very happy with the way our business is moving forward in India. The way customers are responding to our devices, the way we are

able to solve some of the hardest problems, be it how we show up with retail experiences so the customer can actually touch and feel AI experiences or how do we solve for services. Starting 13 August in Delhi, we launch the Pixel Upgrade Programme.

But at the heart of it, we are at Step 1. We have been here in India for a long time. This is a strategic market for Google. This is a strategic market for Pixel, and while we made tremendous progress in the last 18-20 months, we

are still scratching the surface. I want to be in 5,000 cities. We want to reach out to 18,000 pin codes. We want to make sure that every single customer who's looking to get the latest and the greatest of AI technology and is looking to adopt Pixel as a way for them to make their lives better. We are there, so there is a long way to go, and we've just got started.

Q How does Google balance the cost of bringing cutting-edge technology to market with the need to make Pixel compelling for Indian consumers?

A Mitul Shah: One, these rising component prices are impacting the entire industry, and that is not just limited to smartphones. Any and every device which is using RAM is impacted by it.

I actually feel that, more than being price-sensitive, our country is actually a value-sensitive market. As a customer, regardless of what the MRP tag says, you would always know, looking at the device, whether it is worth the value or not. I think that is the core foundation we focused on at least.

Are we maximising value for Indian customers? Regardless of the price point. Now, if you have hardware with seven years of OS security feature upgrades, it has seven years of spare parts guarantee, if that hardware is coming to you with the Pixel Upgrade Programme, if that hardware is safe from future threats like quantum attacks. If that hardware today you can buy with the top two banks in the market, you get tremendous value on your existing device; you get cash back. When you combine all of that and see that the device is also bringing the best of Gemini to you, the best of Google intelligence to you, that is a certain amount of perceived value as a customer you would get out of that device. As long as that value continues to remain relevant for the market, I think we're good. **A**